

Advocate for Persons with Disabilities

2025-2027 Strategic Plan

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Advocate for Persons with Disabilities 2025-2027 Strategic Plan | Assisted Living and Social Services

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Message from the Advocate

Mandated to represent the rights, interests and viewpoints of Albertans, I have heard from thousands of Albertans during my first term as the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities, and what I have heard is that Albertans with disabilities want to experience:

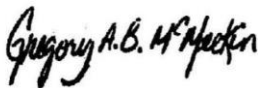
- Authentic and respectful inclusion in all aspects of daily life;
- A high standard of living; and,
- Timely access to supports and services that promote good health, financial stability, excellent accessibility and inclusion.

A prosperous province is inclusive of all and where everyone has a chance to contribute in ways that are meaningful to them and to their communities. Through conversations with Albertans, conducting many consultations on topics ranging from accessibility to mental health, and poring over what I hear from Albertans daily, I have identified three strategic priorities and several objectives that I believe will strengthen inclusion, financial stability and timely access to supports and services. These key priorities including improving access to government services; being a champion of an adequate standard of living; and promoting disability awareness.

I invite you to read my *Advocate for Persons with Disabilities 2025-2027 Strategic Plan*, where I will provide more detail on the priorities and objectives I will undertake.

I look forward to making progress toward these priorities and encourage you to be in contact with the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities with any questions.

Greg A.B. McMeekin, J.D.

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Gregory A.B. McMeekin". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style.

Advocate for Persons with Disabilities

Strategic Priorities and Objectives (2025–2027)

The Advocate's 2025–2027 Strategic Priorities and Objectives focus on improving access to government services, promoting an adequate standard of living, and increasing disability awareness.

By addressing systemic barriers, poverty, and stigma, the OAPD aims to enhance the rights, well-being, and inclusion of Albertans with disabilities.

Priority 1: Promote improvements to accessing government services for persons with disabilities.

- Objective 1.1: Explore challenges in navigating government systems and recommend enhancements to reduce barriers such as administrative burdens, communication challenges, and social isolation.

Priority 2: Champion an Adequate Standard of Living

- Objective 2.1: Explore the experience of poverty among persons with disabilities and its connection to United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD) Article 28 (Adequate Standard of Living).
- Objective 2.2: Review federal and provincial income support programs to identify gaps and recommend improvements.

Priority 3: Promote Disability Awareness Through Education

- Objective 3.1: Identify top issues from OAPD casework and select those issues most likely to benefit from disability awareness.
- Objective 3.2: Design, deliver, and evaluate awareness-raising initiatives using a disability-centered approach.

About the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities

The Advocate for Persons with Disabilities (the Advocate) and the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities (OAPD) represent the rights, interests and well-being of Albertans with disabilities (The Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act, 2018, s 3(1)). The OAPD's dedicated staff build relationships with community members to understand the issues and concerns they face every day.

The Advocate and the OAPD help children, youth, adults and seniors with disabilities access the supports and services available to them. By building relationships with people and stakeholders in the disability community, the Advocate's Office can learn about and bring important issues and concerns to the government with recommendations.

The Advocate and the OAPD act as a point of contact between the community and government. The OAPD supports Albertans with disabilities and other disability stakeholders through support to resolve individual concerns, provide education to promote the rights, interests and well-being of persons with disabilities, and to provide government leaders with information and advice pertaining to gaps in programs and services for persons with disabilities.

Role and Mandate of the Advocate and the OAPD

- The Advocate for Persons with Disabilities (the Advocate) represents the rights, interests, and well-being of Albertans with disabilities, as outlined in the *Advocate for Persons with Disabilities Act (2018)*.
- The Advocate acts as a bridge between the disability community and the government, addressing individual concerns, providing education, and advising on gaps in programs and services.
- Key functions include:
 - Identifying and studying issues affecting persons with disabilities.
 - Reviewing programs and policies.
 - Promoting public education and awareness.
 - Providing recommendations to the government.

Vision, Mission, and Values

- **Vision:** Overcoming adversity, reaching our full potential, and living fulfilling lives.
- **Mission:** To help Albertans with disabilities get access to available supports and help them live with dignity and equal opportunities.
- **Values:** The OAPD promotes the values of self-advocacy, self-determination, human rights, inclusion, well-being, social inclusion, awareness, and education. The OAPD is grounded in the lived experiences of Albertans with disabilities, their families, and their support networks.

How the Priorities and Objectives Were Developed

Strategic Context

The OAPD used a data and research driven approach to determine the 2025 – 2027 Strategic Priorities and Objectives. For data analysis and interpretation, the OAPD aligned with the social model framework of disability, and a human rights-based approach guided by the UNCRPD.

Promote improvements to accessing government services for persons with disabilities.

A key concern Albertans reported to the OAPD included difficulties in systems navigation, particularly around fragmented service delivery and gaps in services.

System navigation involves accessing complex social, health, and economic systems. Challenges include transitions to and from programs, finding services, completing applications, and maintaining access. Barriers include communication difficulties, social isolation, technology challenges, and psychological stress.

Champion an Adequate Standard of Living

Adequate standard of living is rooted in the UNCRPD (Article 28). Albertans consistently report a lack of adequate standard of living to the OAPD. Persons with disabilities, especially those with severe disabilities, face higher poverty rates, and barriers to accessing food, clothing, housing, clean water, disability-related services, and income support programs.

Promote Disability Awareness Through Education

Albertans reported difficulties in communicating with professionals and told the OAPD about the negative effects that difficult interactions have on their overall well-being. Communication difficulties can result from a professional's lack of knowledge and understanding of disability and can arise from stigma (when a large group of people have strong feelings of disapproval toward a specific group) about persons with disabilities. Awareness-raising and education about disabilities that address harmful beliefs about people with disabilities can decrease stigma and counteract ableism.